

COVER STORY

DOMESTIC TOURISM

The Postcard in the Durrung Tea Estate, Assam is surrounded by 1400 acres of sprawling tea plantations (Above)

spreads make way for farm-to-table meals. A seven-course meal cooked by local women in the wilderness is among the highlights for visitors to the Tipeshwar Wildlife Sanctuary in Maharashtra. Chef Amninder Sandhu's open-fire restaurant, Palaash, at Tipai Wildlife Luxuries (rooms from ₹25,000 per night) resort, near the park, is all about slow cooking in underground barbecue pits, or chulhas and sigris with most ingredients plucked from the garden. "My partner always said, people will come to Tipai for the food at Palaash and I would laugh. But that is happening now," says Sandhu. Dishes like a six-hour slow cooked raan and Ambaadi chaat rate high among its many draws. At The Postcard Hotel in Gir (from ₹24,000 per night), the spread ranges from a typical Gujarati thali, Junagarh thali with a range of meats, and a seafood one that brings fresh catch from the Veraval coast.

Wellness experiences have also become an intrinsic part of luxury forest lodges. At Sariska Lodge (from ₹18,500 per night) on the edge of Sariska Tiger Reserve in Rajasthan, visitors rejuvenate with healing crystals and fragrant smoke as Ayurvedic treatments combine with Tibetan healing techniques in an open courtyard. At the edge of Jim Corbett National Park, the French brand L'Occitane spa has found a forest address at Aahana Resort & Spa.

The growing call of connecting with the wild through the prism of luxury is prompting a spate of new property openings. Among those expanding aggressively in this sector is The Postcard Hotel group. "I'm opening Chitwan in Nepal. I have openings in Jawai, Pench and Kanha. I'm signing in Bandhavgarh, Tadoba, Ranthambore and we have a hotel close to Kaziranga," says Chopra.

JW Marriott recently opened a property at Ranthambore (from ₹33,500 per night) and The Leela hotel group is set to launch new ones in Bandhavgarh and Ranthambore. "These upcoming hotels reflect our confidence in the growing appeal of wildlife tourism and the increasing demand for nature-led luxury experiences in India," according to Bhatnagar.

Beyond the traditional wildlife circuit, luxury hotel groups are also opening in under the radar destinations such as the Jawai Leopard Conservation Reserve. Home to free roaming leopards, it is the newest magnet for wildlife enthusiasts. ITC opened Storii at Jawai in March, while The Postcard Hotels is all set to launch a property this October.

NORTHEAST INDIA: A NEW LUXURY TRAVEL FRONTIER

Travelling to experience the Living Roots bridge trek in Meghalaya, spotting the one-horned rhinoceros in Kaziranga's forests and